

FINAL ESSAY – POLITICAL PARTIES AND ELECTIONS IN NORTH AFRICA

The Socialist Forces Front: how this party failed to become efficient.

INTRODUCTION

*“This participation [to the presidential election] has propelled our party to the forefront of the political scene, giving us visibility and presence on a national scale”*¹ said Youcef Aouchiche, the Socialist Forces Front (or *Front des Forces Socialistes*, FFS) candidate to the Algerian president election, during the party’s national council, two months after the unsurprising reelection of president Abdelmadjid Tebboune in September 2024. Even though Aouchiche only got 6,14% of votes according to official results, and the fact that the opposition parties denounced this election to be a fraud, he considered that this election was a victory nonetheless, as it *“consolidated the party as an efficient opposition and offered a political force that enables Algeria to move forward on the path to democracy and progress”*.² However, this discourse may not reflect the reality of the situation.

The Socialist Forces Front, said to be the oldest opposition party in Algeria, was created on September 29th, 1963, by Hocine Aït Ahmed, a strong figure of the Algerian Independence war, after a rift with the National Liberation Front (FLN). After being banned and developing under clandestinity for more than 20 years, it was legalized in 1988, thanks to protests that triggered a process of political liberalization (Baamara, 2017b; Resta & Cavatorta, 2020). However, as 1991 was the only occurrence of a fair multi-party election and as Algeria has since been a “one-party presidential republic dominated by the military” (Resta & Cavatorta, 2020), the FFS has been for more than 30 years an opposition party.

Therefore, this context must be considered to question the position of the FFS in the political landscape, and to determine whether, as Y. Aouchiche sees it, the FFS really is an effective opposition to the regime. “Effective” could be defined as being able, as a party, to seize political opportunities to make inroads, to mobilize the people around your ideas and to be able to frame the political discourse to your advantage. According to I. Jebari (2023), traditional leftist parties in the Arab world are not able to make much of a difference anymore, as most of them were coopted into the political system as the regime’s loyal opposition. These left parties lack mass support, a compelling ideology and a real platform on societal and economic issues, as they primarily focus on calls for democratization and human rights reforms.

Thus, is it possible to consider the FFS’s participation in the election to be a victory? Has the FFS really been able to challenge efficiently the regime and to position itself as a strong opposition party? I will argue that despite favorable conditions, especially since 2019, the FFS is not different from other Arab leftist parties, for several reasons. First, even though the party was able to mobilize and gain some momentum in the 1990’s, its regional roots in Kabylia prevented it to be a strong party on a national scale. Then, under the authoritarian regime, the FFS’ dilemma between boycotting and participating in elections weakened its credibility and political strength over the decades. Finally, its inability to mobilize around class and societal struggles has weakened its support and rendered the party rather ineffective.

¹ (Boufatah, *L'Expression*, 27-10-2024)

² Ibid.

FROM ITS CREATION TO 1991, THE FFS' AMBIVALENT SUCCESS: A PARTY ANCHORED REGIONALLY THAT FAILED TO REACH NATIONAL SUCCESS

Since the creation of the party, the FFS relied heavily on its regional support in Kabylia to develop itself and mobilized people around a strong anti-regime sentiment. It took a long time for the FFS to gain momentum, but it was only really effective in the Kabylia region.

The history of the party explains its anti-regime political conviction. Indeed, right after it was founded, the FFS led for from 1963 to 1965 an armed insurrection in the Kabylia region, after denouncing the authoritarian turn of the regime and calling for democratization (Baamara, 2017b). However, the insurrection failed as the government responded with intense military repression. The rise to power of the single party and the intense repression completed the weakening of the FFS, reducing its influence and consolidating the FLN's monopoly on power. Thus, after the 1965 ceasefire, the FFS was forced to clandestinity, as opposition parties were banned and a contradictory political discourse was forbidden (Baamara, 2017b). For two decades, the party slowly declined, and the Berber militants in Kabylia, the main anchor of the party in the country, prevented the FFS from disappearing. (Baamara, 2017a).

In 1988, the popular protests led to a liberalization of the regime and reforms allowed for free local and general elections. The FFS was authorized to run in the 1990 municipal elections, as it had been legalized, but the party boycotted them, because the FLN took some provisions to maintain its political ascendancy (Tahi, 1992). Even though the FFS did not compete, it was able to influence voter's behavior those election: the party asked its voter base to boycott this election, and this demand was rather followed in Kabylia. Indeed, the region only had 24% of turn out (Tahi, 1992), which can be considered as a mark of the FFS' political effectiveness in this region at that time. Thus, the party consolidated its anti-single-party-regime positions. Nonetheless, it is worth noting that many saw this boycott as a political mistake, as the party could have taken it as an opportunity to become more influent (Monbeig, 1992), in a context where the FLN was increasingly unpopular and many called for social and political reforms.

The 1991 legislative elections represented the high point of the FFS' political influence, even though its popularity was still limited geographically. These elections have been the only fair and free elections in the country, and only the first round out of two took place. In 1990, a meeting of Hocine Aïd Ahmed gathered several hundred thousand people in Algiers, which brought hope that the party would be successful (Monbeig, 1992). It campaigned with claims for increased democratization, for the creation of a constituent assembly to change the regime and positioned itself in opposition to the FLN and to the Islamist Salvation Front (FIS). The FFS competed for 332 seats (of a total of 430) in the National Assembly (Tahi, 1992), but the participation in this election did not allow the FFS to reach power in Algeria, similarly to other leftist parties in the Arab world. The party only got 3,85% of the total votes (Monbeig, 1992; Tahi, 1992), and won 25 seats. The FFS was only really successful in Kabylia, but still challenged the FIS and managed to get more votes than the FLN in Algiers (Monbeig, 1992).

Although the FIS came in first, the FFS was able to gather many people around the rejection of the Islamist party after the first round. On January 2nd, 1992, Hocine Aït Ahmed called for a protest march in Algiers, to 'Save Algeria and Democracy'. The aim was to mobilize as many Algerians as possible, and it was a success, as it became the largest public gathering since Algeria's independence (Tahi, 1992). On this occasion, Ahmed said: "We must reject the Integrist Republic, as we have rejected the Police State"³, showing that the FFS still put forward

³ (Tahi, 1992).

a strong anti-regime sentiment. This political period, which ended with a military coup between the two rounds, could have enabled the FFS to gain an audience on a national scale, but apart from a few important gatherings, its political impact was still limited to the Kabylia region and to the Berber community (Tahi, 1992). The FFS' defense of secularism, modernity and of the Berber community and could have presented a serious challenge to the central government and to other parties but the party was unable to gain momentum around this (Tahi, 1992).

Therefore, from 1963 to 1988, the party was developed in clandestinity, around the resentment of the regime and around calls for democracy, primarily in Kabylia. During the short liberalization period, the FFS was a present in the political landscape, had some symbolical successes, but it seems the party was only an efficient and significant opposition in the Kabylia region.

UNDER AN AUTHORITARIAN REGIME, A FAILURE TO MAKE INROADS: THE FFS BETWEEN BOYCOTTING AND PARTICIPATION

If the FFS had some little success during the 1990's, the party was not able to position itself as an efficient opposition in the last decades, in part because it failed to choose a clear line between boycotting and participating to the regime's elections and political processes. This constant dilemma contributed to weaken its credibility as an opposition to the regime.

According to M. Larbi (2015), Arab leftist parties saw in elections an opportunity to gain status and power, essentially on the local scale. Therefore, these parties, and especially the FFS, adapted and followed the regime's constraining electoral rules. This legal adaptation enabled the FFS to be present in the political landscape, on a local and national scale, but also brought its challenges. Indeed, if this limited participation allows the FFS to have some form of representation, through national deputies or local representatives, and to influence political decisions (if they are able to do so), the party risks to be seen as a "democratic guarantee" (Baamara, 2017b) for the authoritarian regime. This participation is also quite constrained and brings compromises, especially on the local level.

On a national scale, the participation of the FFS to the country's politics as an opposition, under an authoritarian regime, is not quite efficient. According to H. Roberts (2018), the FFS' priority has been to sustain a permanent challenge to the regime, by avoiding any involvement or compromise with the Algerian government, even if they are willing to adopt a policy the FFS approves of and has advocated for. Therefore, the FFS was left out of national politics. This is coherent with their anti-regime sentiment, but it prevented, at times, to take the right opportunities allowing to implement some democratic reforms, especially during the period of political openness in the 1990's (Roberts, 2018). Moreover, the party has a weak political voice in national institutions (as it is an authoritarian system) and this weakness does not allow the FFS to block laws and programs proposed by the government. The FFS representatives have nonetheless some leeway to manifest their disagreement with the regime policies (Baamara, 2017a), but without a concrete impact. Therefore, on a national scale, as the FFS has long followed its anti-regime official stance and has not been coopted by the regime, it could not frame the political discourse to its advantage or counter the regime's positions efficiently.

Moreover, participating can also be much more constraining, especially on the local and regional level and can contradict the FFS' official line. According to L. Baamara (2017a), local representatives have to work with members aligned with the government if they want to

implement policies, as the measures they can take are closely controlled. They can have an impact on society, but not without compromise. Even though the FFS is not coopted by the government, local representatives choose sometimes to work with government representatives to have a say - albeit a limited one - in local and regional policy making. Therefore, this contradicts with the national opposition and anti-regime and anti-government position of the FFS. This paradox between a participation in the regime with an opposition to the regime can sometimes weaken the political stances of the FFS and hurt its credibility. It simultaneously allows it to be a part of the political game, but its political reach can only be limited.

On the other hand, being a local political actor or having national representatives did not prevent the FFS from boycotting elections to criticize the regime. If the party regularly participates in local and regional elections, it has a different position on legislative and presidential election. Indeed, from 1991 to 2024, the FFS never took part in presidential elections, and the party selectively participated in legislative elections, often depending on the political context in Kabylia. For example, in 2002 and 2007, the party boycotted them as a response to the repression of Kabylia staged demonstrations (Del Panta, 2020). These boycotts were in line with the party's anti-regime stance, but because this participation was selective and not systematic, it also contributed at the same time to weaken this discourse. Indeed, it prevented the representation of the FFS as a genuine anti-regime party in the public imaginary. Worse, when it decided to participate in rigged elections, the party could even be seen by some as a "regime puppet" (Del Panta, 2020), and become less credible in the eyes of the voters.

The participation of the FFS in the 2024 presidential elections is a telling example. The party decided, after 25 years of boycott, to present a candidate in the elections, even though they would surely be rigged in favor of president Abdelmadjid Tebboune. The calls of Aouchiche to go vote⁴ represent a turn in the party's boycott tradition : even though participating gave the FFS a political platform, material means and allowed it to hold a political discourse on national media,⁵ it may also have hurt the credibility and the strength of its anti-regime strategy⁶ and contributed to shift the party towards the category of the "loyal oppositions" to the regime (Jebari, 2020). Indeed, even though everybody expected rigged results, Y. Aouchiche called nonetheless for massive turnout in those elections, saying the FFS, if elected, would reform the political system and enable the construction of "a strong social and democratic state".⁷ The very low turnout in these elections⁸ make it possible to consider that the shift from the FFS' boycott of elections to the call for turnout (in elections they knew would be rigged) weakened the party's credibility as an efficient opposition to the government in charge

Thus, the FFS alternated between participation and boycott, which could have been a sufficient strategy to act in a constrained political system as an opposition, but it contributed to weaken the very anti-regime discourse thanks to which it gained some popularity. Moreover, its selective participation, and its candidacy in recent rigged elections contributed to weaken the FFS' credibility as a strong opposition to the regime.

⁴ (Boufatah, *L'Expression*, 27-10-2024)

⁵ (*RFI*, 08-07-2024)

⁶ (Benhami, *L'Expression*, 15-10-2024)

⁷ (*El Khabar*, 24-08-2024)

⁸ (Ayache, *Courrier International*, 12-09-2024)

THE UNABILITY OF THE FFS TO ACT ON THE POPULATION'S DEMANDS

The loss of credibility regarding the anti-regime discourse is important in understanding why the FFS disappointed many voters, but it is not the only cause. Many criticize the FFS for being unable to grasp people's demands, on social or economic subject, but the party is also inefficient in using very favorable contexts, where the demands are very clear, such as protests, to gain popularity.

The FFS has leftist ideas, as it positions itself against neoliberal policies, *rentierism* (Del Pantà, 2020) and supports economic redistribution or the rise of wages during the 2024 elections campaign.⁹ However, the party's incapacity to take advantage of social cleavages is also striking (Del Pantà, 2020) and explains the inefficiency of the FFS as an opposition party.

The lack of organization and structures between the party and the population was an essential factor to the distance between the FFS and the working population. G. Del Pantà (2020) explains that the unprecedented process of deindustrialization in the 1990's-2000's transformed the working class and demobilized people in industrial sectors. As many workers from huge factories ended up working in smaller industries, it was more difficult to mobilize and organize a political movement. Leftist parties, and especially the FFS, failed to reach out to those workers and had no continuous relationship to the social base of the party (Larbi, 2015). Moreover, the FFS was not at the forefront of protests, failed to really engage with the population and workers, and gave limited attention to the social struggles and to the class divide (Del Pantà, 2020). Therefore, as the party has only little support and trust from workers from all over the country, its promises can sound shallow or false.

Another aspect of this failure to address whole sections of the Algerian population is specific to the FFS, especially during the liberalisation period in the 1990's. Indeed, the strong anchor of the party in the Berber community has made social demands secondary (Larbi, 2015), to the benefit of Berber cultural and identity demands. The FFS was long fighting for the recognition by the regime of the Berber community so much so that M. Larbi (2015) considers that this issue actually kept the FFS alive. Therefore, by having political claims that were only relevant in one region of the country, the FFS lost touch with the rest of the population, and was therefore unable to grasp its demands and understand the struggles people faced.

The inability for the FFS to be an efficient political party and opposition to the regime is striking on class issues, but it is also vivid on other subjects, in particular during protests against the regime. The democratic Hirak movement is a great example to show how the party was unable to support efficiently popular demonstrations. This movement started on February 22nd, 2019, to oppose a fifth term of president Abdelaziz Bouteflika, and led to his resignation after being unable to repress the demonstration.¹⁰ The Covid crisis and the repression by the army in the following years under the presidency of A. Tebboune stifled the movement, but these protests were a profitable scenario for the FFS for to gain momentum. As a matter of fact, the population's demands were in line with what the FFS long asked for, such as democratization, liberty, free speech, and were even held mainly in Kabylia at the beginning of the protests.¹¹

⁹ (*El Khabar*, 11-07-2024)

¹⁰ (*L'Orient-Le Jour*, 14-08-2024)

¹¹ (Savoye, *Le Monde*, 26-11-2019)

However, the FFS did not seize this as an opportunity to gain importance, to mobilize the population around its political demands. First, the FFS unable to seize this opportunity due to internal rifts,¹² financial scandals and marginalization of some activists,¹³ which weakened its ability to make the political decisions needed. Moreover, it was not able to act efficiently in this situation, by mobilizing people around its messages or by creating a political narrative that would rally activists, as no coalition was created around a common ambitious project or the goal to find a solution to come out of the crisis.¹⁴

In the end, the FFS supported the Hirak movement, called for liberation of prisoners,¹⁵ but did not make any difference in these protests. It failed at making inroads, not only in workers' protests and on class issues, but also in protests on the very subjects they are used to tackle, such as anti-regime sentiments and democratization of the country.

CONCLUSION

Today, it seems difficult to rely on the oldest opposition party in Algeria to represent a convincing and efficient opposition. The party has had for a long time a strong social anchor in Kabylia, but it failed at really gaining momentum on the national scale during the 1990's liberalization period and in the following decades. The FFS dilemma between participation to the regime's rules and a boycott of the institutions weakened the party's credibility, as it heavily relied on a strong anti-regime and anti-government sentiment. The party's inability to speak about class issues and get close to worker's struggles pushed the FFS away from parts of the population, and its inefficiency to mobilize people and to take concrete actions during social protests makes it appear as an inefficient party. To sum up, the FFS's actions today seem far from enough to consider it to be an efficient opposition to the regime, and the lack of support and of a strong ideological foundation makes it resemble other Arab Left parties that have failed as oppositions to the regime (Jebari, 2023).

An opposition party sometimes moderates its actions and discourses to prevent getting banned or forbidden by the government, but the total lack of action of the FFS today contributes to discredit the party and make voters lose confidence.¹⁶ Recently, the FFS' inability to gain momentum and to capitalize on the Hirak movement during a highly favorable period discredited the party in the eyes of the voters, and Y. Aouchiche's candidacy in the presidential election reinforced this sentiment. Indeed, the low turnout in the 2024 elections, despite the FFS' calls to go vote, stands as a rejection of traditional parties. If the FFS fails to redefine its role and reconnect with the aspirations of the people, it might risk entering the category of "*old, worn-out parties, lacking democratic legitimacy, [which find] their rightful place in museums.*"¹⁷

¹² (Benakli, *L'Expression*, 16-04-2019)

¹³ (Touati, *L'Expression*, 22-04-2019)

¹⁴ (Benhami, *Mondafrique*, 15-10-2024)

¹⁵ (*L'Expression*, 11-07-2019)

¹⁶ (Benhami, *Mondafrique*, 15-10-2024)

¹⁷ *Ibid.*

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